GETTING UP AFTER A FALL

Can you learn to fall safely and get up again?

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Yes. You can learn how to land in a way that protects your bones, and you can practice a step-by-step way to get up from the floor. Both skills should be learned with a therapist or a trained helper, practiced only when it is safe and supervised, and started on a mat or a bed, not a hard floor.

Why this matters

Even with the best plan, some falls still happen. Part of fall prevention is making a fall less harmful: a safer landing, a faster rescue and the skill to get up.

Getting up is a big deal. One in eight older adults who fall lie on the floor for more than an hour, and up to 80% of people over 90 cannot get up on their own. A long lie can bring dehydration, kidney injury, pressure injury, hypothermia (a dangerous drop in body temperature), pneumonia and a loss of confidence. Our earlier article, I've fallen and I can't get up, covers what to do in that moment. This article covers how to prepare.

Falling more safely

These techniques come from fall prevention training. A therapist can adapt them to your body and your health.

- **Tuck and roll.** Let your body rotate as you go down, so you land on large, padded areas like the buttocks and thigh.
- **Squat into a backward fall.** Bending your knees lowers you closer to the ground before you land.
- **Do not catch yourself on a stiff, straight arm.** That reaction is natural, but it can break a wrist.
- **Avoid landing straight on your side when you can.** Falling sideways raises the chance of a hip fracture about sixfold. Strong hip muscles help you stay upright when you start to tip sideways.

Some therapists adapt martial arts break-fall techniques with great care. Always practice on a mat or bed first, with someone beside you.

Getting up from the floor, step by step

The usual sequence looks like this:

1. **Stay still and check for injury.** Take a breath. Do not rush to stand.
2. **Roll onto your side.**

3. **Push up to your hands and knees.**
4. **Crawl to a sturdy chair** or another solid piece of furniture.
5. **Bring one foot forward** so you are in a half-kneel.
6. **Push up and turn to sit** on the chair. Rest before you stand.

Therapists often teach this backward, starting with the last step. You first practice going from kneeling to sitting in a chair. Once that feels easy, you add the step before it, and so on, until you can start from lying on the floor. This builds success at each stage.

If you cannot get up

- Call for help.
- Keep warm. Pull a blanket, towel or clothing over you if you can reach it.
- Shift your position from time to time.
- Stay as comfortable as you can until help arrives.

This is why a phone should be on your body, not across the room. A medical alert button (pendant or wrist, ideally with automatic fall detection) can shorten a long lie, but many older adults wait too long to press it. Practice pressing it so it feels normal. Technology helps, but it never replaces a person checking in.

Who should practice, and how

Practice only when it is safe and supervised. That is especially true if you have osteoporosis, a recent fracture or surgery, dizziness, heart or blood pressure problems, or trouble with balance. Ask your doctor first, and learn from a physical or occupational therapist. In therapy, a floor transfer test checks whether you can get down to and up from the floor, which helps spot who is at risk of a long lie.

A note for family caregivers

If your parent falls and is not hurt, do not drag or lift them. Coach them through the steps above instead, and bring a chair close. Lifting can injure both of you.

If you ever have to call the fire department just to help someone up (a "lift assist"), treat that as a warning sign. It is a reason to ask the doctor for a full falls assessment.

Getting unstuck

Some people freeze in place or feel their balance slipping while standing. The "5 S" method helps:

- **Stop.**
- **Stand tall.**
- **Shake it off.**
- **Shift your weight.**
- **Step forward.**

How Home Safety Solutions can help

During a home safety visit, we look at where a fall is most likely to happen in your home and whether there is a sturdy chair or surface nearby to help you get up. We also look at how you would call for help and suggest a plan your family can practice. Learn what happens during a home safety visit. Call (813) 365-9171 or email info@homesafety.solutions.

Related reading: I've fallen and I can't get up · How do I prevent falls at night? · Find a physical therapist (ChoosePT) · Is it normal to fall as you get older?

This article is general education, not medical advice. Talk with your doctor, pharmacist, or therapist about your own situation.

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